UCR Course Design Resources

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Next: "Canvas Course Components"

Getting Started

The Information and Resources Below Can Help You Develop Your Courses

eLearn (Canvas) allows instructors to centralize course-related information and activities. Regardless of instructional modality, a web-based environment can provide instructors with digital course management tools, and students with increased access and flexibility.

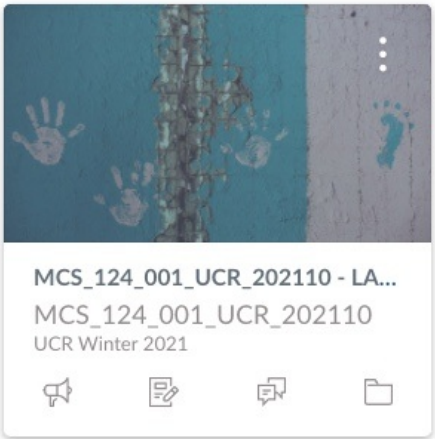
Info: Use of an LMS for In-Person Courses

- How does Canvas work as a supplement to face-to-face courses?

Course Development: Options for Getting Started

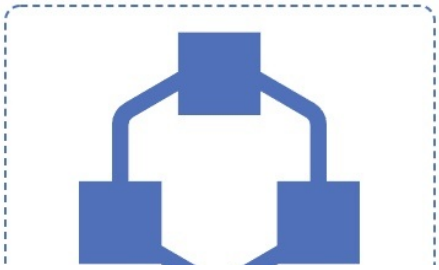
Select one of 3 ways to get started with course development: 1) import or migrate, 2) start from scratch, or 3) use a pre-designed template:

IMPORT OR MIGRATE



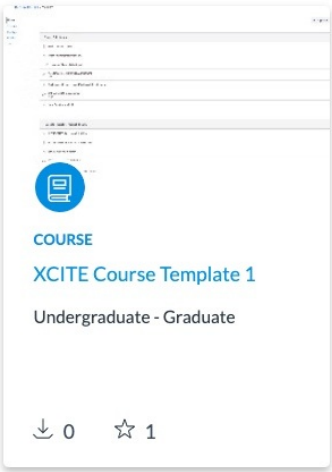
Import from another Canvas course or migrate your course from the iLearn archive (Blackboard) to eLearn (Canvas). Continue to develop the migrated version of your course, located in your Canvas "Dashboard" under "unpublished courses."

START FROM SCRATCH



Starting from scratch allows you to become more familiar with Canvas. It's also an excellent opportunity to redesign and optimize your students' learning experiences. True, it may take more time to build a course from scratch, but keep in mind that you can reuse the content you develop in subsequent terms.

USE A PRE-DESIGNED TEMPLATE



Download a template from the Canvas Commons (HTML) to add to your course shell, and adapt it with the placement of your content in the appropriate places of the course template, within the structure provided.

*Adapted with permission from UCLA at: https://canvas.ucla.edu/courses/288/pages/prepare-your-course-for-winter-2022?module_item_id=3095029

Learn more about these options through the resources in the expander menu below.

Import or Migrate

Canvas makes it easy to "Import Existing Content" into a course, including migrated course content. Email XCITE-help@ucr.edu to request assistance with migration of an archived course. Once your course content has been added to a course shell in eLearn (Canvas), you can continue to develop the course there.

If the official version of your course with enrollments is not yet available, you can use an existing "Sandbox" course, or contact XCITE-help@ucr.edu to request a new course development shell into which you can import or migrate content. When it's time to teach, simply "Import Existing Content" into the official version with enrollments using the option to "Copy a Canvas Course."

Info: Importing or Copying Courses or Course Components

- How do I copy a Canvas course into a new course shell?
- How do I copy a module item to another course?

Copy this "Canvas Course Update Checklist" (GDoc) to your own Google Drive account to make sure your course is ready to be published after a course migration or a course copy.

Start from Scratch

One of the first big decisions you will need to make is: Should I start from scratch? Or should I copy my content over from a migrated version of the course? It may seem like an obvious answer, but not so fast!

Depending on the complexity of a migrated course, you could end up spending as much time reorganizing, paring down, or re-interpreting copied content as you would have spent just having started from scratch.

Start from scratch by creating Modules built from Pages, Assignments, Discussions, and Quizzes. Set due dates, add a syllabus, and deploy videos through the YuJa Media Chooser. Read more about Modules under "Course Components" → "Modules." Read more about YuJa below in the "caution box" called "About Canvas Storage!"

Get an early start using an existing "Sandbox" course, or request a new course development shell by contacting XCITE-help@ucr.edu. When it's time to teach, simply "Import Existing Content" into the official version with enrollments using the option to "Copy a Canvas Course." Read more above under the "Import or Migrate" expander

menu option.

Use a Pre-Designed Template

Pre-designed course and syllabus templates are available for import from the Canvas Commons into your Canvas course sites. These templates contain boilerplate verbiage, prompts, and placeholders to help get you started with course development.

Available XCITE templates include:

- XCITE Syllabus Template 1 (HTML)
- XCITE Syllabus Template 1 (GDoc)
- XCITE Course Template 1 (HTML)
- XCITE Course Template 2 (HTML)
- Academic Integrity Policy Agreement (HTML)

Info: Resources about the Canvas Commons

- What is Canvas Commons?
- How do I use Commons?
- How do I import and view a Commons resource in Canvas?

How to Import a Template from Canvas Commons

Adapted with permission from https://bruinlearn.ucla.edu/courses/288/pages/access-ucla-canvas-course-templates

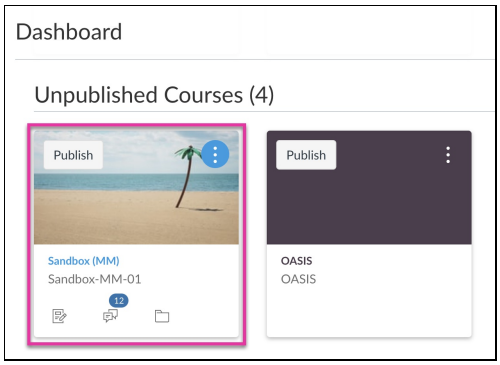
1. Authorize Commons

If you have not yet authorized the use of Commons, you will need to do the following before selecting a template to import:

1. Click on the "Commons" button in the left-hand Canvas Global Navigation Menu
2. Click the "Authorize" button to authorize access to Commons

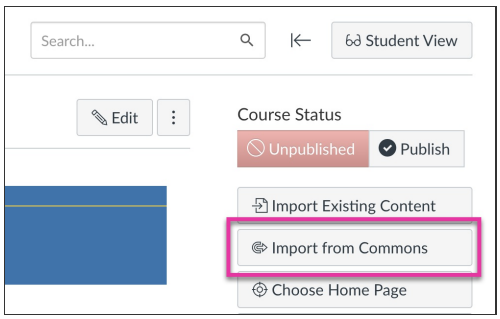
2. Select a Course

Select an empty course shell or sandbox site in which to install a template by clicking on its name in "Courses" view, or its tile in "Dashboard" view:



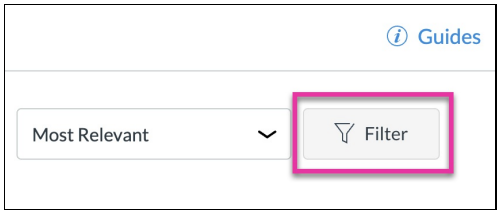
3. Go to Commons

Click the "Import from Commons" button located on the Home page or Settings page, either on the right side or at the bottom of the screen, depending on your monitor or display:

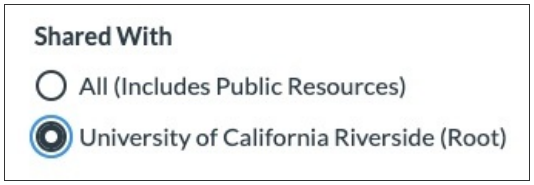


4. Filter Templates

On the top right of the Canvas Commons, click on the "Filter" button:

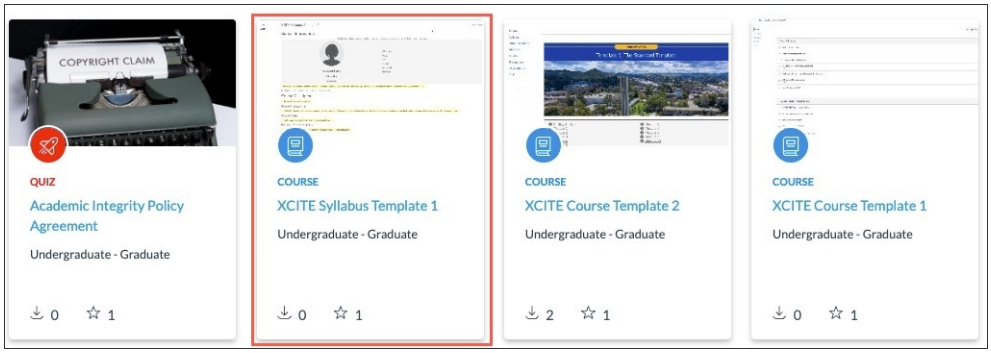


On the "Filter Results" screen under "Shared With," select the "University of California Riverside" radio button and close the Filter Results window:

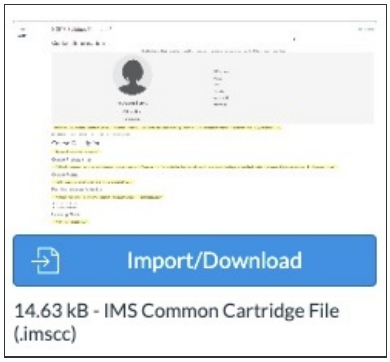


5. Import Template

You should now see all the templates available to you. Click on the title of the template you would like to install:

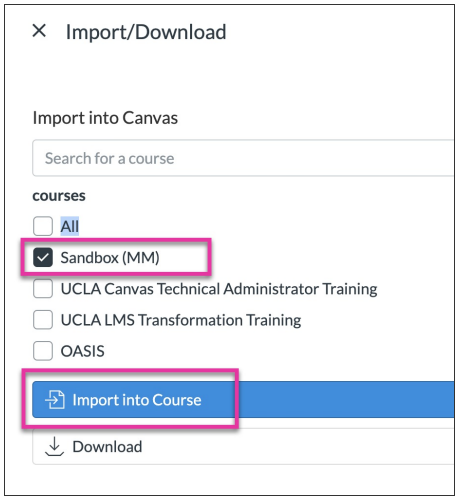


Click on the "Import/Download" button located on the right side of the screen:



Select the radio button for the course you want to import the template into, and then click the "Import into Course" button:

NOTE: You can only import templates into courses in which you have an active role (e.g. Teacher, etc.)

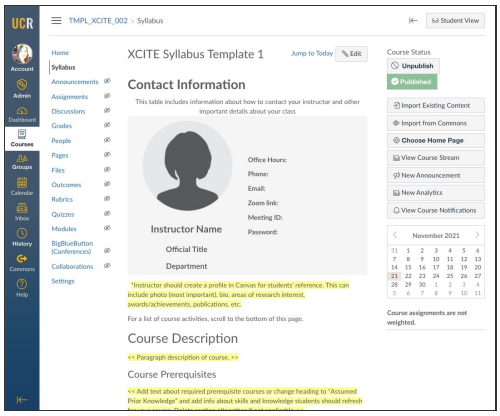


6. Complete Import

You will receive a message at the top of the screen informing you that the import has successfully started:

You have successfully started the import! It may take a little while to see changes in your course.

Navigate back to your course, and after a few minutes, the template will be available from within your course:



⚠ **Caution:** About Media Usage and Storage!

Each Canvas course now allows up to 2GB of storage, although only 500MB can be allocated to multimedia files, including audio or video file formats. YuJa has unlimited storage and is integrated with Canvas. Instructors may need to be selective about which content to host and deliver natively through Canvas, the integrated YuJa tool, or other campus platforms.

Access your personal, YuJa account through the YuJa link in your course navigation menu.

YuJa is capable of hosting all file formats, including video. See "How to upload YuJa documents to Canvas."

See also:

- Embedding Content in Canvas Using the YuJa Media Chooser
- Adding Lumina (YuJa) Media to Canvas Modules

Note about copyright: It's important to be mindful of copyright when uploading to YuJa files or media found online, or from other sources. According to Fair Use, it's perfectly legal to stream content with attribution through Canvas from original, source locations. However, permissions may vary when users download and then upload materials or media for playback and distribution outside of intended contexts. Read more at the UCR Library's Copyright & Teaching webpage, or find more resources at the informational page called "UCR Library Resources and Services." See the library resource called "Open Textbooks and Other Open Education Resources: A Selection" for ideas of ways to use more open-source and copyright free materials or media in your courses.

✱ Course Suggestions

Set a welcoming tone for learners entering your course by including the following elements:

Welcome Message

A written or recorded "Welcome" message can help to set a friendly and inviting tone. A "Welcome" message can serve as an introduction to a course and its instructor(s) or TAs. Include your perspective on why the course is important to the field or discipline, and what you hope students will take away from the learning experience. Combine a "Welcome" message with a course "walkthrough" to orient students to major assignments or course components, and to point out important aspects of your syllabus. Post a "Welcome" message on the course Home Page, as an Announcement, or on a Page within a Module, such as a "Course Orientation" or "Getting Started" Module.

Meet and Greet Discussion Forum

A "Meet and Greet" discussion forum can help your students to get to know each other and create a sense of community. Have your students take a moment to introduce themselves to one another. Encourage each student to share their year and major, along with the reason they're taking the course. Engage your students to update their Canvas profile pictures by providing the instructions "How do I add a profile picture in my user account as a student?"

Course Materials

Course materials uploaded to the Files area of your course can be linked to text on Canvas Pages or inserted into Modules as stand-alone documents. Use Canvas Modules to integrate course materials within the context of the course structure, according to the corresponding week, unit, or topic. Although Modules can group categories of course materials, as with a "Course Resources" Module, this "material category" approach to using Modules is less integrative.

Read more about Canvas Modules on the Course Components Page.